Chapter 2 — From Hunting–Gathering to Growing Food

> **The one-line point:** For ~2 million years humans wandered and ate what they found. Then, ~10,000 years ago, they started *growing* food — and within a few thousand years we had cities, kings, taxes and armies. **This is the single biggest change in human history.**

← Ch.1 | Index | Next: Ch.3 →

🏷️ Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → **Ancient India**
Sub-discipline	**Prehistory** (Palaeolithic, Mesolithic, Neolithic)
Period	~2 million years ago → ~4,500 years ago
Prelims (GS Paper I)	*History of India* → Stone Age cultures, Neolithic sites, prehistoric art
Mains (GS Paper I)	Weak directly; **Bhimbetka** enters via **Art & Culture** (rock art). Also feeds "Indian Society" (tribal communities)
Also feeds	**Art & Culture** (Bhimbetka rock paintings — a UNESCO site), **Geography** (site locations), **Environment** (domestication, human–environment interaction)
Weightage	⭐⭐⭐ — 0–2 Prelims Qs. Site-matching is the usual format
Overlaps with	Bhimbetka appears in **UNESCO World Heritage** lists (asked in Prelims 2013, 2020 style)

> 🧭 **Not Modern History, not Medieval.** This is **Ancient India → Prehistory**. The only piece that crosses into **Art & Culture** is Bhimbetka.

🎯 Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- [ ] **Distinguish** Palaeolithic, Mesolithic and Neolithic by their tools, dates and lifestyle.
- [ ] **Define** and identify a **microlith**, and explain why it was a technological leap.
- [ ] **Explain** what a hunter-gatherer band actually did across a year, and why they had to move.
- [ ] **Locate and match** the key sites: Bhimbetka, Mehrgarh, Burzahom, Chirand, Koldihwa, Mahagara, Daojali Hading, Hallur, Paiyampalli, Bagor, Adamgarh, Kurnool caves, Hunsgi.
- [ ] **Explain domestication** of plants and animals — what humans actually changed, and why it's a *gradual* process, not an event.
- [ ] **Argue** why farming produced surplus, and why surplus produced inequality, specialists, and eventually the state.
- [ ] **Describe** the Mehrgarh evidence in detail — why it is the single most important Neolithic site in the subcontinent.
- [ ] **Distinguish** factory sites from habitation sites from habitation-cum-factory sites.

- [ ] **Explain** the significance of Bhimbetka's rock paintings for Art & Culture.
- [ ] **Evaluate** the honest trade-off: farming gave more food but arguably a *worse* life. State both sides.

🎬 Start Here: 2 Million Years in One Image

Human beings have existed for about **2 million years.** Farming is about **10,000 years** old.

Let's make that ratio real:

```
If all of human existence were ONE 24-HOUR DAY:

00:00 ──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────► 24:00
 │                                                                      │
 │◄──────────────── HUNTING & GATHERING (23 hrs 53 min) ──────────────►│
 │                                                                      │
 │                                                        FARMING ───► │
 │                                                   starts at 23:53    │
 │                                                                      │
 │                                                         CITIES ───► │
 │                                                           23:56      │
 │                                                                      │
 │                                                     YOU, TODAY ───► │
 │                                                           24:00      │
```

Farming occupies the last 7 minutes of the human day. Everything you think of as "civilisation" — cities, writing, kings, money, laws, software — happens in those final minutes.

Understand this and the whole book reorganises itself. Chapters 3–10 are all describing those last 7 minutes. This chapter describes the other 23 hours and 53 minutes.

💻 The Software Engineer's Analogy

Hunter-gatherers ran a **stateless, horizontally-distributed, ephemeral system.**

```
┌──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
│ HUNTER-GATHERER ARCHITECTURE          FARMING ARCHITECTURE           │
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
│                                                                      │
│ Stateless                       →     Stateful                       │
│ (carry nothing, own nothing)          (granary = persistent          │
│                                        storage on disk)              │
│                                                                      │
│ Ephemeral / autoscaling         →     Pinned to a host               │
│ (move when resources deplete)         (you CANNOT move — your        │
│                                        crop is in the ground)        │
│                                                                      │
│ Small bands, no hierarchy       →     Large settlements,             │
│ (flat team, ~25 people)               specialised roles,             │
│                                        management layer              │
│                                                                      │
│ No surplus                      →     SURPLUS                        │
│ (consume what you gather)             (which someone must            │
│                                        guard, count, and             │
│                                        eventually TAX)               │
│                                                                      │
│ Generalists                     →     Specialists                    │
│ (everyone does everything)            (potter, weaver, priest,       │
│                                        soldier, scribe)              │
└──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┘
```

🔑 **The whole causal chain in one line: Storage → surplus → specialists → hierarchy → the state.**

Once you can *persist* food, you can support people who don't produce food. Those people become priests, soldiers, kings and record-keepers. **Every chapter after this one is a consequence of inventing storage.**

1️⃣ Life Before Farming: The Hunter-Gatherers

What did they actually eat?

Not just meat. NCERT is clear — the "gathering" half did most of the feeding.

```
┌─────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
│      THE HUNTER-GATHERER FOOD BASKET            │
├─────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
│                                                 │
│     GATHERED (the bulk of the diet)             │
│     • Fruits, nuts, seeds                       │
│     • Roots, tubers                             │
│     • Leafy plants                              │
│     • Honey                                     │
│     • Eggs (incl. OSTRICH eggs)                 │
│                                                 │
│     HUNTED                                      │
│     • Deer, wild boar, wild cattle              │
│     • Small game, birds                         │
│                                                 │
│     FISHED                                      │
│     • River and coastal fish                    │
│                                                 │
└─────────────────────────────────────────────────┘
```

🥚 **Ostrich eggshell** — a genuinely striking detail. Ostriches lived in India during the Palaeolithic. **Decorated ostrich eggshell** pieces were found at **Patne (Maharashtra)** — evidence of both the animal's presence and of early art. This is exactly the kind of specific detail Prelims likes.

Why did they have to keep moving? Four reasons

Reason	Explanation
1. Resource depletion	Stay in one place and you eat all the plants and animals there. Move on, let it regenerate — an early form of sustainability, by necessity
2. Animal migration	Animals move in search of their own food; hunters follow the herds
3. Seasonality of plants	Fruits ripen in different seasons in different places. You follow the calendar across the landscape
4. Water	In dry seasons, water shrinks to a few rivers and lakes. You must go where water is

💻 **This is literally "follow the workload."** They scaled to where the resources were, and tore down the deployment when the resource pool depleted. Zero persistent state, because persistent state would pin them to a location they'd have to abandon.

Their toolkit: stone, and why we call it the Stone Age

Made of stone	Made of wood/bone (mostly lost to us)
Hand-axes, choppers, blades	Spear shafts, digging sticks
Scrapers (for hides)	Bows, arrows shafts
Points, borers	Baskets, traps, nets

Stone tools were used to: cut meat and bone, scrape bark and hides, chop fruit and roots, and — crucially — **make other tools out of wood and bone**.

> ⚠️ Remember Chapter 1's survival-bias lesson: we call it the "Stone Age" because **stone survived**, not because stone was the main material. Their world was probably mostly wood, fibre and leather — all of which rotted away.

🔥 Fire — the underrated revolution

Evidence of fire comes from **Kurnool caves (Andhra Pradesh)** — ash deposits.

Fire changed four things at once:

1. **Light** — extends the usable day beyond sunset
2. **Cooking** — makes food softer, safer (kills parasites) and releases far more calories per bite
3. **Protection** — keeps predators away at night
4. **Warmth** — opens up colder regions and seasons

> 🧠 **The deeper point:** cooking is *external pre-digestion*. It offloads work from your gut to the fire. Anthropologists argue this is precisely what let human guts shrink and human brains grow — brains are metabolically expensive, and cooking paid for them.

Three kinds of archaeological site — a distinction UPSC uses

```
┌──────────────────────────┐  ┌──────────────────────────┐  ┌──────────────────────────┐
│   HABITATION SITE        │  │    FACTORY SITE          │  │ HABITATION-CUM-          │
│                          │  │                          │  │ FACTORY SITE             │
│  Where people LIVED      │  │ Where raw stone was      │  │                          │
│                          │  │ available and tools      │  │ People both LIVED        │
│  Find: hearths, food     │  │ were MADE                │  │ and MADE tools here      │
│  remains, huts, waste    │  │                          │  │                          │
│                          │  │ Find: waste flakes,      │  │ Find: BOTH sets of       │
│                          │  │ half-finished tools,     │  │ evidence together        │
│                          │  │ NO living debris         │  │                          │
└──────────────────────────┘  └──────────────────────────┘  └──────────────────────────┘
```

Factory sites cluster near **rivers and streams**, because that's where usable stone (quartzite pebbles) was found.

2️⃣ The Three Stone Ages — Learn This Table Cold

This is the highest-value table in the chapter.

	PALAEOLITHIC 🪨	MESOLITHIC 🔪	NEOLITHIC 🌾
Meaning	Greek *palaeo* = old, *lithos* = stone → **Old Stone Age**	*meso* = middle → **Middle Stone Age**	*neo* = new → **New Stone Age**
When	2 million – 12,000 years ago	**12,000 – 10,000** years ago	**10,000 – 4,500** years ago
Tools	Large, rough, chipped: hand-axes, choppers, cleavers	**MICROLITHS** — tiny (1–2 cm) stone tools, hafted onto wood/bone handles	**Polished/ground** stone tools; also querns, mortars, pestles
Lifestyle	Nomadic hunter-gatherer	Hunter-gatherer, but **more settled**; beginning of herding	**FARMING + HERDING**; settled villages
Housing	Caves, rock shelters, open air	Caves, seasonal camps	**Permanent huts**, pit-dwellings
Pottery	None	Rare	**Yes** — needed to store and cook grain
Key sites	Hunsgi, Kurnool caves, Bhimbetka, Narmada valley	Bagor, Adamgarh, Bhimbetka (upper layers), Sarai Nahar Rai	Mehrgarh, Burzahom, Chirand, Koldihwa, Mahagara, Daojali Hading
Sub-divided into	Lower, Middle, Upper Palaeolithic	—	—

🔪 Microliths — why they were a genuine leap

A microlith is a **tiny stone blade, 1–2 cm long.** On its own it's useless. The invention wasn't the blade — **it was the idea of mounting many small blades into a handle.**

```
        BEFORE (Palaeolithic)              AFTER (Mesolithic)
       ──────────────────────             ──────────────────

       One big heavy hand-axe             Wooden/bone shaft
       held directly in the hand          ┌───────────────────────────┐
                                          │▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ │ │
              ___                         └───────────────────────────┘
             /   \                          ↑ ↑ ↑ ↑ ↑
            / ███ \                        microliths set in resin
           /  ███  \
           \  ███  /                      → SICKLES for cutting grass/grain
            \_███_/                       → ARROWS and SPEARS (light, fast)
                                          → SAWS and knives
       Heavy. Slow. One function.
       Blunt = throw the whole tool away.
                                          Modular. Light. Replaceable.
                                          One blade chips? Swap it out.
```

> 💻 **This is modularity and component reuse.** The Palaeolithic hand-axe is a monolith — one giant object doing one job, and when part of it fails you discard the whole thing. Microliths are **composable components with a standard interface** (the haft). Same blades, different assemblies: sickle, arrow, spear, saw. And **repair becomes cheap** — replace the failing component, keep the system.
>
> Microliths also made the **bow and arrow** viable, which let humans kill at a distance and hunt fast, small animals. That's a genuine capability unlock.

🎨 Bhimbetka — the site that appears in two syllabus areas

Bhimbetka (Madhya Pradesh, near Bhopal, in the Vindhyas)

Fact	Detail
What it is	A vast complex of **natural rock shelters and caves**
Occupied	From the Palaeolithic through the Mesolithic and beyond — an extraordinarily long, continuous record
Famous for	**Prehistoric rock paintings** — hundreds of shelters with art
Paintings show	Hunting scenes, animals (bison, deer, elephants, tigers), dancing, group activity, later even horse riders
Colours used	Natural mineral pigments — **red (haematite/geru)** and **white (limestone)**; some green and yellow
Status	**UNESCO World Heritage Site (2003)**
Why the shelters	Natural caves gave protection from rain, heat and wind — and they sit near water and a rich forest

> 🎯 **Double-scoring site.** Bhimbetka is asked in Prelims both as *prehistory* and as *Art & Culture* (India's oldest art), and it shows up in UNESCO World Heritage question sets. **Know it from all three angles.**

> 🧠 **Why paint at all?** NCERT invites you to think about it. Likely reasons: ritual/magic (paint the hunt to make it succeed), record-keeping, teaching the young, or simply art. We don't know — and saying "we don't know, but here are the hypotheses" is a *stronger* answer than pretending certainty.

3️⃣ The Neolithic Revolution — How Farming Began

Nobody decided to invent farming

This is the most misunderstood point in the chapter. There was no eureka moment. It was **gradual, accidental, and took thousands of years.**

```
  THE PLAUSIBLE SEQUENCE
  ══════════════════════

  1. People gather wild grasses (wheat, barley, rice) for food
                          ↓
  2. Seeds spill near the camp — around rubbish heaps and hearths
                          ↓
  3. Next season, those seeds SPROUT right where people live
                          ↓
  4. People notice. They start protecting these patches from birds and animals
                          ↓
  5. They begin deliberately scattering seed, watering, weeding
                          ↓
  6. They save seed from the BEST plants (biggest grain, doesn't shatter)
                          ↓
  7. Over many generations the plant CHANGES — this is DOMESTICATION
                          ↓
  8. You must now STAY to guard, tend and harvest → SETTLED LIFE
```

> 💻 **Step 6 is a selection algorithm running on a genome, executed by humans over centuries.** Each season is one generation; the fitness function is "what humans keep and replant." Domestication is *selective breeding without anyone knowing genetics existed*. The wheat you eat today is the output of ~10,000 years of that loop.

🌡️ The trigger: climate change

Around **12,000 years ago** the last Ice Age ended. The world warmed. Consequences:

- **Grasslands expanded** → more wild wheat, barley and rice growing naturally
- **Animals that eat grass multiplied** → deer, antelope, goat, sheep, cattle

- **More reliable, denser food in fixed locations** → less reason to wander

Climate created the opportunity; humans took it. (A useful Environment/Geography crossover: major human transitions often track climate shifts.)

What "domestication" actually means

> **Domestication** = the process by which people **grow plants and rear animals**, selecting and changing them over generations to suit human needs.

	Wild	Domesticated
Wheat/barley	Small grain; ear **shatters** to scatter seed naturally	Bigger grain; ear **holds together** so it can be harvested
Animals	Aggressive, flighty, breed seasonally	Docile, tolerate humans, breed more readily, larger yield

The first domesticated animal: the DOG. ⭐ (Remember this — it's a frequent one-liner question.)

Then: **sheep, goat, cattle, pig, buffalo.**

The first domesticated plants: WHEAT and BARLEY. Then rice, millets, pulses, cotton.

🌎 Where did which crop start? — The wild-ancestor logic

NCERT makes an elegant point: **a crop was domesticated where its wild ancestor grows.**

Crop	Where domesticated in the subcontinent
Wheat & Barley	**North-west** — Sulaiman/Kirthar hills region (**Mehrgarh**)
Rice	**North of the Vindhyas** — Ganga valley (Koldihwa, Mahagara, Chirand)
Millets	**Deccan / South India** (Hallur, Paiyampalli)
Cotton	North-west (Mehrgarh — among the world's earliest cotton)

> 🧠 **Two things to take from this:** (1) farming began **independently in several regions**, not from one origin point. (2) The crop map you memorise here explains later regional economies — the Ganga's rice surplus is exactly why Magadha becomes a superpower in Chapter 5.

🐄 Herding and pastoralism

Alongside farming, some groups became **herders/pastoralists** — moving with flocks of sheep, goats and cattle rather than settling.

Why animals were so valuable — an insight worth internalising:

> Animals are **"walking storage."** A field of grain must be harvested and stored in a pot that can rot, burn or be stolen. A herd of goats stores food *on the hoof*, reproduces on its own, and **walks itself** to the next pasture. It gives milk, meat, hide, wool, dung (fuel and fertiliser) and traction — all while multiplying.

> 💻 **A herd is a self-replicating, self-relocating data store with continuous yield.** No wonder cattle became the unit of wealth. In Chapter 4 you'll see the Rigvedic word for "war" literally means *"search for cattle"* (**gavishti**). Wealth = cattle, so raiding cattle = getting rich.

4️⃣ The Great Sites — Learn These as Pairs

This is the **highest-frequency Prelims content** in the chapter. Match sites to their claim to fame.

```
                    NEOLITHIC INDIA — SITE MAP (schematic)
   ┌─────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
   │                         /\/\ HIMALAYAS /\/\                          │
   │       * BURZAHOM (Kashmir)                                          │
   │       * GUFKRAL (Kashmir)         pit-dwellings, dog buried        │
   │                                   with master                       │
   │  * MEHRGARH                                   * DAOJALI HADING      │
   │  (Bolan Pass, Baluchistan)                      (Assam, NE)         │
   │  wheat, barley, cotton,            * CHIRAND     jadeite, stone     │
   │  sheep, goat, CATTLE                 (Bihar)     mortars            │
   │  burials w/ goats                    bone tools                     │
   │                                                                     │
   │          * BAGOR (Raj.)   * KOLDIHWA & MAHAGARA (UP)                │
   │            Mesolithic       * SARAI NAHAR RAI     RICE — earliest   │
   │                                                                     │
   │     ▓▓▓ VINDHYAS ▓▓▓  * BHIMBETKA (MP) — rock art                   │
   │                       * ADAMGARH (MP) — Mesolithic, animal bones    │
   │                                                                     │
   │            * HUNSGI (Karnataka) — Palaeolithic                      │
   │            * HALLUR (Karnataka) — millets, ash mounds               │
   │            * PAIYAMPALLI (Tamil Nadu) — millets, pulses             │
   │            * KURNOOL CAVES (AP) — evidence of FIRE                  │
   │                                                                     │
   └─────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┘
```

The site table — memorise this

Site	Region	Period	Famous for
Mehrgarh ⭐⭐⭐	Bolan Pass, Baluchistan	Neolithic (~8,000 yrs ago)	**Earliest farming village** in the subcontinent; wheat, barley, **cotton**; sheep, goat, **cattle**; square/rectangular mud-brick houses with storage compartments; **burials with goats**
Burzahom ⭐⭐	Kashmir	Neolithic	**PIT-DWELLINGS** (houses dug into the ground); **dogs buried with their masters**; bone tools
Gufkral	Kashmir	Neolithic	Pit dwellings; "cave of the potter"
Chirand	Bihar (Ganga valley)	Neolithic	Extensive **bone and antler tools**
Koldihwa & Mahagara ⭐⭐	Uttar Pradesh (Belan valley)	Neolithic	**Earliest evidence of RICE**; Mahagara has a **cattle pen with hoof marks**
Daojali Hading ⭐	Assam (NE, near China/Myanmar)	Neolithic	Stone **mortars and pestles**; **jadeite** — a stone possibly from **China**, hinting at long-distance contact
Hallur	Karnataka	Neolithic	**Millets**; South Indian **ash mounds**
Paiyampalli	Tamil Nadu	Neolithic	**Millets and pulses**
Bhimbetka ⭐⭐⭐	Madhya Pradesh	Palaeo → Meso	**Rock paintings**; caves and shelters; **UNESCO site**
Hunsgi	Karnataka	Palaeolithic	Major Palaeolithic site cluster
Kurnool caves ⭐	Andhra Pradesh	Palaeolithic	Evidence of **FIRE** (ash)
Bagor ⭐	Rajasthan	Mesolithic	Long occupation; microliths; **early herding** of sheep/goat
Adamgarh	Madhya Pradesh	Mesolithic	Microliths; **animal bones — earliest domestication evidence**
Sarai Nahar Rai	Uttar Pradesh	Mesolithic	Human burials, microliths
Patne	Maharashtra	Upper Palaeolithic	**Decorated ostrich eggshell**

> 🧠 **Memory hooks that actually work:**
>
> - **Burzahom** → "*Burrow*-zahom" → people **burrowed** pit-dwellings. And dogs buried with masters.
> - **Mehrgarh** → "*Mehr*" sounds like "more" → **more of everything**: the *first* and *richest* farming site. Wheat, barley, cotton, cattle.
> - **Koldihwa** → "*Kol-DHAAN*-wa" (*dhan* = paddy) → **RICE**.
> - **Daojali Hading** → far NE, near China → **jadeite from China**.
> - **Kurnool** → "*Kur*" ≈ *jal*-ao/burn → **FIRE**.

🏆 Mehrgarh in detail — the site you cannot afford to skip

Mehrgarh sits on the **Bolan Pass** in Baluchistan — one of the main routes into the subcontinent from Iran and Central Asia. Location is not a coincidence.

Why it matters so much:

1. **Earliest evidence of farming and herding** in the subcontinent (~8,000 years ago)
2. **Crops:** wheat and barley — and later **cotton**, among the earliest cotton anywhere in the world
3. **Animals:** the sequence is important — sheep and goat first, then **cattle**, which became dominant
4. **Houses:** square/rectangular **mud-brick** houses with **several compartments**, some likely for **storing grain** ← *the birth of persistent storage*

5. **Burials:** the dead buried with **goats** — implying belief in an afterlife where the animal would be needed, and implying animals were valued property
6. **Continuity:** occupied for thousands of years, right up to the Harappan era. **Mehrgarh is the bridge between the Neolithic and Chapter 3's cities.**

> 🔗 **Connect forward:** Mehrgarh's mud-brick houses, cotton, cattle and grain storage are the *seed* of everything you'll read in Chapter 3. The Harappan civilisation didn't appear from nowhere — it grew out of villages like this one.

5️⃣ What Changed When People Settled Down

The visible changes

Before (mobile)	After (settled)
Caves, temporary shelters	**Permanent houses** — mud-brick, wattle-and-daub, pit-dwellings
Carry everything you own	**Accumulate possessions** — heavy pots, furniture, stored grain
Eat what you find, when you find it	**Store food** in pots and pits → survive lean seasons
Everyone does every task	**Specialisation** — potters, weavers, tool-makers
Bands of ~20–50	**Villages** of hundreds
No pottery (nothing to store)	**Pottery everywhere** — for storage, cooking, and serving
Rough/chipped stone tools	**Polished** stone tools; **querns, mortars, pestles** for grinding grain

🍚 Why pottery is a bigger deal than it sounds

Pottery arrives *with* farming, and that is not a coincidence.

- **Grain must be stored** — protected from rats, damp and insects. A sealed pot does that.
- **Grain must be cooked** — hard cereals need long boiling in water. You cannot boil water on an open fire without a **fire-resistant, waterproof container**.
- Pottery also becomes **archaeology's most useful fossil**: it breaks constantly, is thrown away, never decays, and its style changes by region and era.

> 💻 **Pottery styles are like framework versions in a dependency file.** Archaeologists date and connect sites by pottery type the same way you'd date a codebase by its lockfile. "Northern Black Polished Ware" (Chapter 8) is a marker of a whole era.

⚖️ The honest trade-off — and why UPSC likes this angle

Farming is usually taught as pure progress. **The evidence says otherwise.** Skeletons from early farming communities are often *shorter*, with *worse teeth* and *more disease* than the hunter-gatherers before them.

Farming gave you	Farming cost you
More calories per acre → bigger population	**Less varied diet** → 2–3 staple crops instead of 100+ wild foods → nutritional deficiency
Storable surplus → survive bad seasons	**Crop failure = famine**. Hunter-gatherers just moved; farmers starved
Settled life → possessions, houses, community	**Backbreaking labour** — hunter-gatherers worked fewer hours per week
Specialists → potters, priests, artists	**New diseases** — living close to animals and dense human settlement (zoonotic disease, sanitation)
Cities and civilisation	**INEQUALITY** — surplus can be owned, hoarded, inherited and taxed. Property, class and slavery all become possible

> 🎯 **This trade-off is genuinely useful for Mains and Essay.** It's the original case study for *"development for whom?"* — an increase in aggregate output that reduced individual wellbeing while enabling everything we now call civilisation. Deploy it in essays on progress, growth vs. wellbeing, or technology and society.

6️⃣ Tribal Societies — The Living Link

NCERT makes a point that carries forward into Indian Society (GS1):

> **Hunting-gathering and shifting cultivation did not "end."** Communities practising them survive in India today.

- Tribal groups continue **hunting, gathering forest produce**, and **shifting cultivation** (**jhum**), especially in central and north-east India.
- Their societies typically have **little social hierarchy**, and land is often held **communally** rather than as private property.
- Their knowledge of forests, plants and medicine is deep and precise.
- They are often marginalised **precisely because** their relationship with land doesn't fit a settled-agriculture, private-property, revenue-collecting state.

> 🔗 **Cross-link to your Polity notes:** this is the historical root of the **Fifth and Sixth Schedules**, the **Forest Rights Act 2006**, **PESA 1996**, and the constitutional category of **Scheduled Tribes**. Ancient History and Polity meet here — and GS1's "Indian Society" section asks about it directly.

Jhum / shifting cultivation, briefly: clear a forest patch → burn the vegetation (ash fertilises) → sow → cultivate 2–3 years → move to a new patch and let the old one regenerate over 10–20 years. Sustainable at low population density; damaging when cycles are compressed.

⚡ UPSC FOCUS

Prelims — high-probability content

Topic	The specific thing to know
Site matching ⭐⭐⭐	The single most common format. Master the site table above
Burzahom	**Pit-dwellings** + **dog buried with master**
Mehrgarh	Earliest farming; wheat, barley, **cotton**; **burials with goats**; Bolan Pass
Koldihwa / Mahagara	**Rice**; cattle pen with hoof marks
Daojali Hading	**Jadeite** — hints at contact with China
Bhimbetka	Rock paintings; **UNESCO World Heritage**; also an Art & Culture item
First domesticated animal	**Dog**
First domesticated crops	**Wheat and barley**
Microliths	Defining tool of the **Mesolithic**
Kurnool caves	Evidence of **fire**
Patne	**Ostrich eggshell**
Neolithic tool types	**Polished/ground** — plus querns, mortars, pestles

Common trap: confusing Mesolithic (microliths, ~12,000–10,000 yrs ago) with Neolithic (polished tools + farming, ~10,000 yrs ago). **Microliths ≠ farming.** Mesolithic people used microliths and were *still* hunter-gatherers (though some began herding).

Second trap: assuming farming began at one place and spread. It began **independently** in several regions — wheat in the NW, rice in the Ganga valley, millets in the south.

Mains — where you'd actually use this

Rarely asked directly. Deploy it as:

- **Art & Culture:** Bhimbetka as the earliest expression of Indian art — subject matter, technique, pigments, continuity of tradition.
- **Indian Society (GS1):** tribal communities, shifting cultivation, forest rights, and why settled-agriculture states marginalise mobile peoples.
- **Essay:** the Neolithic trade-off as the archetypal "progress vs. wellbeing" case study.
- **Environment:** domestication as the first large-scale human reshaping of ecosystems.

🔑 Glossary

Term	Meaning
Palaeolithic	Old Stone Age; 2 mya–12,000 yrs ago; rough chipped tools
Mesolithic	Middle Stone Age; 12,000–10,000 yrs ago; **microliths**
Neolithic	New Stone Age; 10,000–4,500 yrs ago; polished tools + **farming**
Microlith	Tiny (1–2 cm) stone tool hafted into wood/bone handles
Domestication	Growing plants and rearing animals, changing them over generations to suit human needs
Hunter-gatherer	One who lives by hunting animals and gathering wild plants
Pastoralist / herder	One who lives by rearing and moving with herds
Habitation site	Where people lived
Factory site	Where tools were made (near stone sources)
Habitation-cum-factory site	Both together
Quern	Flat stone slab for grinding grain
Pit-dwelling	House dug into the ground, entered by ladder (**Burzahom**)
Jhum	Shifting/slash-and-burn cultivation
Haematite (geru)	Red mineral pigment used in rock paintings
Ash mound	Large mounds of burnt cow dung found at South Indian Neolithic sites

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🔁 60-Second Recap

1. **Humans existed ~2 million years; farming is only ~10,000 years old** — the last 7 minutes of a 24-hour day.
2. **Three Stone Ages:** Palaeolithic (rough tools, nomadic) → Mesolithic (**microliths**, semi-settled, herding begins) → Neolithic (**polished tools + farming**, settled villages).
3. **Microliths were a modularity breakthrough** — small replaceable blades hafted into handles; enabled sickles, bows and arrows.
4. **Bhimbetka** = rock paintings, UNESCO site, India's oldest art. **Kurnool caves** = fire. **Patne** = ostrich eggshell.
5. **Climate change ~12,000 years ago** ended the Ice Age, expanded grasslands, and made farming possible.
6. **Domestication was gradual selective breeding.** First animal = **dog**. First crops = **wheat and barley**.
7. **Farming began independently in several regions** — wheat/barley NW, rice Ganga valley, millets south.
8. **Mehrgarh** is the keystone site: earliest farming, cotton, cattle, mud-brick houses with storage, burials with goats, and continuous occupation into the Harappan era.
9. **Burzahom** = pit-dwellings + dogs buried with masters. **Koldihwa/Mahagara** = rice. **Daojali Hading** = jadeite from China.
10. **Settling down → storage → surplus → specialists → hierarchy → the state.** This chain drives every later chapter.
11. **Farming was a genuine trade-off** — more food, worse health, and the birth of inequality.
12. **Hunter-gatherers and shifting cultivators still exist** in India — the root of Fifth/Sixth Schedule and Forest Rights debates.

✍️ Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Consider the following statements about Burzahom:
    1. It is located in the Kashmir valley.
    2. Its inhabitants lived in pit-dwellings.
    3. Dogs were buried along with their masters. How many are correct? → *All three*.
2. Which of the following pairs is/are correctly matched?
    1. Koldihwa — earliest evidence of rice
    2. Daojali Hading — jadeite, suggesting contact with China
    3. Paiyampalli — cotton cultivation → *1 and 2 only. Paiyampalli = millets and pulses; cotton is Mehrgarh.*
3. The defining tool type of the Mesolithic period was — → *Microliths*.
4. Consider the following:
    1. Mehrgarh provides the earliest evidence of cotton cultivation in the subcontinent.
    2. At Mehrgarh, the dead were sometimes buried with goats.
    3. Mehrgarh is located near the Khyber Pass. → *1 and 2 only. Mehrgarh is on the* ***Bolan*** *Pass, not the Khyber.*

Mains style

5. *"The transition from hunting-gathering to agriculture was not an unambiguous improvement in human wellbeing."* Critically examine. **(150 words)**
6. Discuss the significance of the Bhimbetka rock shelters in understanding the origins of art in the Indian subcontinent. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Name three Neolithic sites and one distinguishing feature of each.
- Explain, in one causal chain, how food storage eventually produced kings.
- What is the difference between a factory site and a habitation site?
- Why is it wrong to say farming was "invented"?

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